THE STEADY ROOM

Holiday Boundaries Text Pack

20 kind, clear messages for family and in-laws you can copy, paste, and send.

Free from The Steady Room

Why this pack exists

The holidays bring up the same few hard moments every year: who hosts, how long a visit lasts, the comment at dinner, the gift budget. Most of us know what we want. The hard part is finding words that are warm and clear without a long defense attached.

These messages are short on purpose. A boundary works best when you state your plan, show you care, and then stop explaining. The longer the reason, the more there is to argue with.

How to use it

1. Pick the message closest to your situation and change the names, dates, and times.
2. Send it early. October and early November give everyone time to plan.
3. Agree with your partner first. Usually each person speaks to their own family.
4. Say it once, kindly. If someone pushes, repeat the plan (see message 6). You don't need a new reason.
5. Pair every 'no' with a 'yes' when you can: a different date, a call, a dessert.
6. Then follow through on what you said you'd do. That is the boundary.

The 20 messages

1. ANNOUNCING YOUR PLAN EARLY

Hi everyone! We're planning our holidays early this year so nobody is guessing. We'll be with you on the 25th from 1 to 5 pm. We're really looking forward to it.

2. HOSTING AT YOUR OWN PLACE

We've decided to host a small Thanksgiving at our place this year. We'd love to see you the weekend after. Can we pick a day now?

3. NOT STAYING OVERNIGHT

We'd love to come for dinner. We've booked a hotel nearby so the kids can keep their routine, so we'll head out around 8.

4. SAYING NO TO THE TRIP

Thank you so much for inviting us. We can't make the trip this year. We need a quiet holiday at home. Could we plan a visit in the spring?

5. SPLITTING TIME FAIRLY

We're splitting the holidays between both families this year, so we'll be with you on Christmas Eve and with Sam's parents on Christmas Day.

6. WHEN THEY PUSH BACK

I know you're disappointed, and I'd feel the same. Our plan is still the same this year. Let's put a date on the calendar for January.

7. SETTING A VISIT LENGTH

We're so glad you're coming! We have room for you from Friday to Sunday morning. After that we're back to work-week mode.

8. TOPICS OFF THE TABLE

Quick request for Thursday: could we keep politics off the table this year? I'd love for the day to be about catching up.

9. COMMENTS ABOUT WEIGHT OR FOOD

Please skip comments about my plate or my body this year. I'd much rather hear how you've been.

10. COMMENTS ABOUT YOUR PARENTING

I hear you. We've thought this one through, and this is how we're handling it. How's your garden doing?

11. GIFT SPENDING LIMIT

We're keeping gifts simple this year: one small gift per person, under $25. Thank you for understanding, it really helps us.

12. KIDS-ONLY GIFTS

This year we're doing gifts for the kids only. Your company is honestly the best part for the adults.

13. DECLINING TO HOST

We won't be able to host this year, but we'd love to bring dessert wherever we land.

14. ARRIVING LATE OR LEAVING EARLY

We'll be there for dessert around 6. We have an early morning, so we'll head out by 8:30.

15. PARTNER-TO-PARTNER CHECK-IN

Before Saturday, can we agree on our leave time and a signal if one of us needs a break? I want us to feel like a team.

16. YOUR PARTNER TALKS TO THEIR FAMILY

I think this lands better coming from you. Could you let your mom know our plan by Sunday? I'll back you up.

17. PAUSING A HEATED MOMENT

I want to keep talking about this, just not right now. Let's pick it up after the holidays, when we can both be calm.

18. ALCOHOL LIMIT

We're keeping it to one round of drinks at our place this year. We'll have plenty of good non-alcoholic options too.

19. RECONNECTING AFTER DISTANCE

I've missed you. I'd like this year to feel easier between us. Could we have a coffee before the big day, just us?

20. AFTER IT GOES WRONG

I'm sorry about how the dinner ended. I care about us. I'd like to talk when we've both had a little time. Does next week work?

Your own version

Use the formula: warm opener + your plan + one connection point.

Who I need to tell:

My plan (dates, times, limits):

My message, word for word:

If they push back, I will say:

Want the full toolkit? The Steady Room Boundaries Workbook walks you through scripts, worksheets, and follow-through for every relationship in your life.